

Time's Table

Fiction

The house was ancient — crooked black beams, a mossy tiled roof, crumbling brick chimneys at either end. Todd stared up at it from the car and thought: how was it even still standing?

His great-grandfather's home. His parents had insisted on visiting. Todd's dad had been particularly jolly all morning — a sure sign that something was expected of him. This was not his world.

His mum had given him strict instructions on the drive up. Shake hands. Say please and thank you. Be interesting. And above all: behave. He had been promised a new game if everything went well.

Todd sat stiffly in the drawing room. The armchairs were enormous and smelt of old paper. His great-grandfather — a small, thin man with bright, clever eyes — beamed at them from across the room and gave Todd a subtle wink when his parents weren't looking. Todd liked him for that.

"You must be bored stiff, young Todd," his great-grandfather said after a while. "Why don't you go and explore? There's plenty to see."

Todd jumped up at the opportunity to escape, just remembering to say thank you before he scuttled out of the room. His parents' gaze followed him to the door.

He wandered through corridors lined with oil paintings. The portraits were all stern-faced, their eyes following him wherever he went. Keen to escape their gaze, he pushed open a heavy door and found himself in the dining room.

Running down the length of the room was a grand dining table, dark and gleaming. On it sat silver bowls and candlesticks and tall vases of flowers. Todd walked slowly along the side of the table, trailing his fingers along the edge.

Dinner was brought in shortly afterwards, and Todd sat quietly while the adults talked. The conversation droned on and on. He would have a long wait before he was able to move. He occupied himself by looking at the table's elaborate carved legs.

That was when he noticed it — beneath the table, hidden in the carved decoration, a flat silver disc about the size of his palm. He ducked his head under. There were small holes in the disc, in a circle, just the right size for fingertips.

He reached up and found they exactly matched. He fitted his fingertips into the holes. The long-serving housekeeper moved past at that very moment and Todd felt a flash of panic — but she did not look down.

He gave the disc a little twist — anticlockwise. Something clicked, deep inside the table. The silver disc rotated smoothly, perfectly, as if it had been made for his hands alone.

A soft light pulsed from within the wood. Todd pulled his hand back and sat up straight, his heart hammering.

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In the drawing room, he could hear his great-grandfather chuckling at something. Todd looked back under the table. The disc was still. The light was gone. But it had been there. He had felt it.